ANSHA MONTESSORI TEACHER TRAINING INSTITUTE (AMTTI)

- A Division of Ansha Group of Education

PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

MONTESSORI TEACHER TRAINING COURSE

Course Code: AMTTC–004

Prepared in accordance with the requirements of
Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE)
and Teacher Training Programmes

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ABOUT THE INSTITUTION

Ansha Montessori Teacher Training Institute (AMTTI) is a division of the Ansha Group of Education, established in October 2014 with the objective of promoting quality teacher education in early childhood care and education.

The institute is committed to preparing competent and professionally trained educators through a structured Montessori-based approach. AMTTI emphasizes child-centred education, developmentally appropriate practices, and the creation of a prepared learning environment that supports holistic child development.

The institute adopts a balanced training methodology that integrates theoretical foundations with supervised practical experience, enabling trainee teachers to acquire essential pedagogical skills, classroom management techniques, and professional competence required for early childhood education settings.

AMTTI functions with the support of an experienced academic and administrative team and adheres to recognized educational standards to ensure the quality and relevance of its teacher training programmes.

ABOUT THE FOUNDER

Mrs. Shakila Hussain, Founder of Ansha Montessori Teacher Training Institute, holds academic qualifications including M.Phil, M.Ed, and PGDGC. With more than 15 years of experience in the field of education, she has played a key role in establishing and guiding the institute with a focus on academic integrity, professional teacher preparation, and child-centred educational practices.

INSTITUTIONAL PHILOSOPHY

The institute is grounded in Montessori principles such as observation, freedom with responsibility, and respect for the child. AMTTI views the learning environment as a supportive and structured space that encourages independence, responsibility, and active participation in the learning process.

PREFACE

Quality experiences are vital for the growth and development of every child. For enhancing the learning levels of children at the elementary education stage, it is essential that all children are provided with good quality preschool education. Therefore quality preschool education is one of the goals covered under NEP 2020. It is vital to invest in these early years by ensuring an emotionally supportive and stimulating play-based environment for every child. The NEP 2020 emphasises for three years of preschool education before Class I.

This material deals with Preschool Management focusing on the collective efforts of subject experts, teachers and teacher educators.

The compilers and the advisory team hope with this material a support to the preschool teachers by giving a hand to care their children. We are thankful to all those who gave their suggestions. We welcome comments and constructive suggestions to bring further improvement in the quality and usability of this material.

Regards

Development Team

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Unit 1: PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

1.1 INTRODUCTION

The early years are the most significant years for human growth, development and learning of all children including those with special needs due to disability conditions. The all-round capacities that emerge in three to six years age group are the pre-requisites for later success in school and life. Pre-schooling is the early education that occurs at preschool. A preschool is an educational establishment or learning space offering early childhood education to children before they begin compulsory education at primary school. It may be publicly or privately operated, and may be subsidized from public funds. It also aims to integrate the various domains of development with the expected learning outcomes in ways that are compatible with the natural learning behaviour of young children in this age group.

UNICEF's work on early childhood development (ECD) recognizes the essential building blocks for every growing child: nurturing care, good health, optimal nutrition and a stimulating and safe environment for all-round development and learning.

1.2 MEANING OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

"Preschool education is the education imparted to children in 3–6 years of age group. It is the first stage of organised education. Preschool education is also known as pre-primary education. It is provided in any of the settings, such as Anganwadies, nursery schools, preschools, preparatory schools, kindergartens, Montessori schools and pre-primary sections in government and private schools."

— NCERT

"Preprimary education is critical for establishing a solid foundation for a child's social, emotional and overall well-being. The early years of a child's life build the basis for lifelong growth, and children who fall behind in these early years often never catch up with their peers, leaving them more likely to drop out of school and fail to reach their full potential. Though there are varying standards, preprimary education programmes are typically designed for children of 3 to 5 years of age."

— UNICEF

Early childhood education as an interactive process in the sphere of life at home, day care and preschool is purposefully aimed at an all-encompassing personality development of children between the age from 0 to 6 years. Care, education and teaching in early childhood education are integrated into one functional entity.

— Ojala

1.3 HISTORY OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

In an age when school was restricted to children who had already learned to read and write at home, there were many attempts to make school accessible for orphans or to the children of women who worked in factories.

In 1779, Johann Friedrich Oberlin and Louise Scheppler founded in Strasbourg an early establishment for caring and educating preschool children whose parents were absent during the day.

At about the same time, in 1780, similar infant establishments were established in Bavaria. In 1802, Pauline zur Lippe established a preschool centre in Detmold.

In 1816, Robert Owen, a philosopher and pedagogue, opened the first British and probably globally the first infant school in New Lanark, Scotland. In conjunction with his venture for cooperative mills Owen wanted the children to be given a good moral

education so that they would be fit for work. His system was successful in producing obedient children with basic literacy and numeracy.

Samuel Wilderspin opened his first infant school in London in 1819, and went on to establish hundreds more. He published many works on the subject, and his work became the model for infant schools throughout England and further.

Play was an important part of Wilderspin's system of education. He is credited with inventing the playground. In 1823, Wilderspin published *On the Importance of Educating the Infant Poor*, based on the school he ran. He began working for the Infant School Society the next year, informing others about his views. He also wrote *The Infant System*, for developing the physical, intellectual, and moral powers of all children from one to seven years of age.

The German educator Friedrich Froebel is significant for developing an idealist philosophy of early childhood education and establishing the kindergarten, a school for four- and five-year-old children that is found worldwide. He is also known as the father of early childhood education. Froebel opened a Play and Activity Institute in 1837 in the village of Bad Blankenburg in the principality of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt in Thuringia which he renamed Kindergarten on 28 June 1840.

In 1829 in Italy, the Agazzi sisters Rosa and Carolina initiated a blending of Italian's infant school and Froebel Kindergarten and produced a prototypical Italian infant school (*Scuola materna*). In the school the children were introduced to objects from real life as well as Froebelian symbolic objects to examine.

One of the most famous figures in preschool education, Maria Montessori, who began her studies of educational problems with culturally deprived and mentally deficient children in 1899, became director of the Orthophrenic School in Rome. She felt that they might yield even better results with normal children. Thus, in 1907, she took

under her care 60 children, aged three to six, from the slums of the San Lorenzo quarter of Rome and thus inaugurated her first *Casa dei Bambini* (Children's House).

Global Developments in ECCE

The 1990s opened a new page in the history of the development of ECCE catalysed mainly by the rapid successive ratification of the 1989 United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC). Article 6 explicitly mentions the child — "every human being under the age of 18". The CRC reinforced the 1960 UNESCO Convention and Recommendation against Discrimination in Education which should have covered young children in any case.

With its moral force and near universal ratification, the CRC formally recognised children as holders of rights to survival and development, to be heard and participate in decisions affecting them in accordance with their evolving capacities. While the CRC in Article 18 also recognizes the primary role of parents and legal guardians in the upbringing and development of children, it obliges States Parties to help them carry out these duties.

The second boost to the development of ECCE was the adoption of the World Declaration on Education for All (EFA) in March 1990 in Jomtien, Thailand. Reflecting General Comment 7, the Jomtien Declaration explicitly stated that "learning begins at birth", and called for early childhood care and initial education (Article 5). This novel recognition of ECCE as an integral part of basic education featured again in the major goals adopted at the 1990 UN World Summit for Children. Ten years later, in 2000, this expanded vision of basic education was reaffirmed in the Dakar Framework for Action on EFA, adopted at the World Education Forum as the first of the six EFA goals: Expanding and improving comprehensive ECCE especially for the most

vulnerable and disadvantaged children. Regrettably, unlike other EFA goals, this was stated as a broad aspirational goal without numerical targets or clear benchmarks.

ECCE was further reinforced by the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs). Albeit only partially adopted at the UN Millennium Summit in 2000, two of the MDGs had direct relevance to early childhood development:

- Improving maternal health, with the targets of reducing the maternal mortality rates by three-quarters and providing universal access to reproductive health (MDG4)
- Reducing the under-five mortality rate by two-thirds between 1990 and 2015 (MDG5).

Thus, the child and maternal health aspects of ECCE became part and parcel of a global effort to meet the needs of the world's poorest, while childcare and early education aspects were left out.

In recent decades, ECCE has further received attention from stakeholders including researchers, community and civil society and intergovernmental organizations which further received understanding of its holistic and multisectoral nature. Research continues to document the multifaceted development benefits of ECCE for health, education, social and emotional well-being, social equity and cohesion, the economy, employment and earnings.

1.3.1 India: Pre-School Education

The pre-school education in India is also known as kindergarten, a term created by Mr Friedrich Froebel in 1837, which means "children's garden". Various types of pre-school education are now available in India, and more and more children are now attending preschool, indicating a rise in demand for education of kids. Pre-school

education is considered to be very important for education of kids. Pre-school education is the first step towards entering the world of knowledge as well as independent and purposeful life. Pre-school education helps children become more independent and confident as well as promote the all-round development of the children.

The preschool journey in India is divided into two stages:
i. **Junior Kindergarten (Jr. KG)** – children three to four years of age
ii. **Senior Kindergarten (Sr. KG)** – children aged four to five years

A child enters Class 1 of school once he is done with the Sr. KG. Kindergarten plays an important part of regular schools, as well it is part of separate private chain. This versatility is because education in India is provided by the public sector as well as the private sector. Government control and funding coming from three levels: central, state, and local. Children belonging to low-income groups in society, particularly girls, depend on public preschools. Education of children between 3–6 years old is not a fundamental right, thus it is not in the thick light.

1.4 VISION OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

Preschool education promotes the holistic, inclusive and contextualised development of children between 3–6 years of age. These can be ensured by involving parents and teachers in providing an emotionally supportive, culturally rooted, child oriented and stimulating learning environment. It aims at maximising individual potential by creating strong foundations for lifelong learning through play and developmentally appropriate practices. It also intends to develop healthy attitude, good values, skills of critical thinking, collaboration, communication, creativity, technology, literacy and socio-emotional development. It ensures smooth transition

from preschool to primary school, thus enabling children for productive and satisfying life in future.

1.5 AIMS OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

- Provide a strong foundation for all round development and life-long learning.
- Prepare the child for school.
- Maximises individual potential.
- Develop health and adequate environment.
- Develop good values.
- Develop skills.
- Develop collaboration.
- Develop communication.
- Develop literacy.

1.6 OBJECTIVES OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

- To provide a child-friendly environment that is safe, secure, caring and stimulating.
- To enhance the development and education of children through play.
- To encourage children to develop self-confidence and self-esteem and to feel valued as an individual.
- To promote children's social, intellectual and physical development through play and structured activities, preparing them for a smooth transition from pre-school to school.

- To regularly observe and plan for each child's progress.
- To honour parents' trust that we will nurture their child and give them quality care.
- To work within the guidelines of the Early Years Foundation Stage.
- To follow the guidelines and requirements of the registering bodies.

1.7 FEATURES OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

- A good head start for learning.
- Teaching in a fun filled way (play method).
- Learn by playing.
- Putting children on a path of life-long learning.
- Higher development in language and mathematical skills.
- A great opportunity to develop social skills.
- Exposure to enhance communication skills.

1.8 GUIDING PRINCIPLES IN PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

The preschool phase is the building stone for future life. The pace of learning is particularly fast in this phase; the growth developmental characteristics of a specific age group are common for all in that group; however, it must not be forgotten that each child is unique in himself or herself. Preschool education is based on some principles. These principles can be listed as follows:

- Preschool education should consider the needs of children and individual differences.

- Preschool education should support the psychomotor, social, emotional, linguistic and cognitive development of the child, build in self-care skills and prepare the child for primary education.
- To respond to the needs of children, preschool education institutions should provide education environments in compliance with an understanding of democratic education.
- While arranging for activities, means of the community and school should be considered in addition to the needs and fields of interests of children.
- The process of education should start from what children already know and provide opportunity for learning by trying and experimenting.
- Education given in preschool phase should be contributory to the development of children in terms of affection, respect, cooperation, responsibility, tolerance, solidarity and self-control.
- Education should impart in children self-respect, self-confidence and self-control.
- Play is the best method of learning for children in this age group. All activities must be arranged on the basis of play.
- While communicating with children, no behaviour that can hurt their personality should be allowed and there must be no place for intimidation or restrictions.
- Children should be supported in developing independent behaviour and adult support, guidance and comforting proximity should be in place when they need help.

- Children should be supported in recognizing the emotions of themselves and others.
- Children should be supported in developing their imagination, creative and critical thinking skills, communicative and self-expressive powers.
- While developing programmes, circumstances in the family and close environments should be taken into account.
- The child and his/her family should actively take part in the process of education.

1.9 IMPORTANCE OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

Preschool education helps in a child's emotional, social and personal growth and development. Thus it is of great importance for a preschool to have plenty of things to attract the attention of their students.

According to the Institute of Early Education Research (IEER), children who attend a good preschool have better pre-reading, Maths and science skills than those who did not attend preschool. Although a child learns more from home in preschool, continuous interaction and exposure with children of same age group and teachers helps them build a strong foundation in social, communication skills that will give them a leg up in school and beyond. Preschool provides opportunities for children to learn in ways that interest them, building a positive association with learning.

The best preschool helps the children develop a drive to learn that they will take with them throughout their time in school. When children play and engage in activities with their peers, there will be inevitable minor conflicts that bring frustration, anger, and other emotional challenges.

At preschool, teachers offer a variety of games and activities that help children build pre-literacy skills. Children sing alphabet songs, learn rhymes that help them distinguish between sounds, listen to read-aloud stories, and play with magnetic alphabet letters. In addition to learning these foundations, children often develop a sense of excitement and motivation to continue learning.

Preschool pre-literacy learning takes place during activities that are inherently interesting to children, which builds positive associations with reading, while literacy, math, and cognitive skills are not the only ones that young children should learn. Many preschool activities help children develop physical coordination and fine motor skills. Children are challenged to develop control of their fingers with projects that involve threading beads, drawing, or using scissors. Many preschools also offer daily opportunities for children to challenge themselves by jumping or hopping.

Last but not the least reason for preschool education's importance is that it helps children prepare for kindergarten, which has gotten increasingly academic.

1.10 SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

1. What do you mean by preschool education?
2. Write a note on theoretical background of preschool education.
3. What are the guiding principles of preschool education?
4. Write a note on importance of preschool education.

1.11 PRACTICAL WORK / PROJECT / ASSIGNMENT

- Visit a nearby Anganwadi and find out the functions performed by an Anganwadi Teacher.

For Further Reading

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Unit 2: DIFFERENT POLICIES AND COUNCILS FOR PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

2.1 INTRODUCTION

With the intention of revamp, the educational scenario, the government setup many commissions and committees and make many policies time to time for addressing different issues of education. It consists of the principles and policies that influence the field of education, as well as the collection of laws and rules that govern the operation of education systems.

2.2 SARGENT REPORT

The British took many initiatives to spread education in India one of which was the Sargent report in Education 1944. John Sargent was given the responsibility to create a comprehensive scheme for Indian education in 1944. A committee of 22 members was set up. They submitted their report in 1944 to the Central Advisory Board of Education who accepted the report and agreed to its implementation. This report was the first attempt towards the development of the Indian national education system. It visualized a system of education with pre-primary education for children between

3 to 6 years of age; universal, compulsory and free primary basic education for all children between the ages 6—11 (junior basic) and 11—14 (senior basic) as suggested in Wardha Scheme; the Senior Basic or the Middle School to be the final stage in the school career of majority of the students. The report also recommended that at the Middle School stage, provision should be made for a variety of courses.

2.2.1 Recommendations

- It recommended the establishment of primary schools for the promotion and enhancement of general behaviour and social experience.
- The report recommended that education for the pre-primary and nursery stage should be free.
- It recommended that the schools must be divided into two groups – junior basic schools and senior basic schools.
- Trained and competent teachers were to be appointed by the schools as per this report. They had to be well trained and educated.
- The report also recommended that the medium of instruction should be the mother tongue while English should be compulsory and be taught as the second language.
- The report also recommended educating people about 40 years of age.
- Vocational, technical education, general education were recommended for them.

2.2.2 Sargent report and Pre-school Education

According to the Sargent report (1944), the main objectives of education at the pre-primary stage should be to give young children social experience rather than formal instruction.

- To develop understanding of foundations of preschool education.
- Growth and development in early childhood (0–5 yrs). Development of skills to manage an early childhood care and education centres.
- Provide guidance / knowledge for working effectively with parents and communities for education of pre-school children.
- To gain knowledge and develop skills and attitude required for working with young children.

2.3 THE SECONDARY EDUCATION COMMISSION (1952–53)

The Government of India established the Secondary Education Commission on 23 September 1952 under the chairmanship of Dr. Lakshmana Swamy Mudaliar. It was called the Mudaliar Commission after him. The commission recommended diversifying the curriculum, adding an intermediate level, introducing three-tier undergraduate courses, etc.

2.3.1 Objectives of Mudaliar commission

- To study the condition of compulsory secondary education and to suggest measures for its reorganization.
- To study the aims, curriculum, teaching standard of secondary education of every province in India.
- To study the pay-scales & service conditions of secondary school teachers.
- To study the condition of secondary schools in every province.
- To study the examination system of secondary level.

- To study the problems of secondary education in every province & suggest their remedies.

2.3.2 The Commission's Findings

- Installation of higher secondary system.
- Diversified courses.
- Three language formula.
- Emphasis on education and vocational guidance.

2.3.3 Secondary Education Commission and Pre-Schooling

- Introducing the child to the joys of learning through companionship and creative activities.
- Providing opportunities for developing proper habits of life, cleanliness and healthy modes of living.
- Cultivation of social habits necessary for a community life.

2.4 CHILD CARE COMMITTEE (1963–64)

Under the chairperson Smt. B. Tarabai, the committee identified the following objectives of preschool:

- Taking very great care of the physical development of the child in the key early years in terms of health, nutrition, posture and capacities.
- Developing habits of cleanliness in the pre-school child at home as well as in the school.
- Providing adequate nourishment in kind and quantity for growth of vigorous healthy bodies.
- Providing facilities for training and exercise in personal cleanliness and hygienic habits.

- Providing playground activities and hand work activities necessary to develop all the skills of the child to deal with the environment.
- Providing opportunities for the emotional development of the child.
- Providing opportunities for developing good behaviour patterns.

2.5 INDIAN EDUCATION COMMISSION (1964–66)

National Education Commission (1964–1966), popularly known as Kothari Commission, was an ad hoc commission set up by the Government of India to examine all aspects of the educational sector in India, to evolve a general pattern of education and to advise guidelines and policies for the development of education in India.

2.5.1 Recommendations of Kothari Commission

- Provision of free and compulsory education recommended providing free and compulsory education for children aged 6 to 14 years.
- Languages – The Commission recommended adopting a three-language formula in all state levels. It intended to promote a language of the Southern states in Hindi speaking states. It intended to promote Hindi, English and a regional language in non-Hindi speaking states.
- The Kothari Commission recommended promoting regional languages, Sanskrit as well as international languages, preferably English.
- The Kothari Commission recommended providing favourable and adequate service conditions for teachers and providing them with the necessary freedom to conduct and publish those findings.

2.5.2 Indian Education Commission on Pre-school

- To develop the child for good health habits and to build up basic skills necessary for personal adjustment such as dressing, toilet habits, eating, washing, cleaning etc.
- To develop desirable social attitudes and manners and to encourage healthy group participation making the child sensitive to the rights and privileges of others.
- To develop emotional maturity by guiding the child to express, understand, accept and control his feelings and emotions.
- To encourage aesthetic appreciation.
- To stimulate the beginning of intellectual curiosity concerning the environment and to help him understand the world in which he lives and foster new interests through opportunities to explore investigate and experiments.
- To encourage independence and creativity by providing the child with sufficient opportunities for self-expression.
- To develop the child's ability to express his thoughts and feelings in fluent, correct and clear speech.

2.6 REPORT OF THE STUDY GROUP 1972

The study group was appointed jointly by the Ministry of Education and the Department of social welfare (which was a part of the ministry of law and social welfare). The group consisted of 13 members including the chairperson Smt. Mina Swaminathan, Sri J. P. Naik was the member secretary of the group.

The group made several recommendations on the development of the pre-school child.

- To promote child health through periodic health care so as to reduce child mortality and morbidity and offer protection against communicable diseases.
- To promote optimum nutritional standards during the formative years of the child's life to enable him to develop his innate physical and mental potentialities to the full.
- To promote a proper climate and to adopt measures for the healthy and balanced growth of the social and emotional aspects for the child's personality.
- To reduce educational disparities by providing planned environmental stimulation aimed at supporting development of the cognitive abilities of the child.
- To build readiness in the child for school learning and thus to help combat wastage and stagnation in the first two years of primary schools.
- To promote an environment of security, love and acceptance and to help the child to build up desirable attitude, values and behaviours.

2.7 NATIONAL POLICY ON EDUCATION (1986)

In the post-independence period, reconstruction of educational system was the major concern of the Government of India. The National Policy of Education (NPE) is a policy formulated by the Government of India to promote education among Indians in urban and rural area. Based on the report and recommendation of the Education Commission, the Government of India announced the National Policy of Education. The first NPE was promulgated by Indira Gandhi in 1968 and the second by Rajiv Gandhi in 1986.

The new National Policy of Education laid special emphasis on the removal of disparities and equalizing educational opportunity for Indian women, Scheduled Tribes (STs), Scheduled Castes (SCs) and communities. The National Policy of Education (NPE) was adopted by Parliament in May, 1986.

NPE, 1986 recommended a National System of Education. The concept of national system of education implies that up to a given level, all students, irrespective of caste, creed, location or sex have access to education of a comparable quality. To achieve this, government will initiate appropriately funded programmes.

2.7.1 National Policy on Education (1986) and Pre School

The National Policy on Education (1986) realising the importance of ECCE in the education of a child, had urged the government to include ECCE too under the purview of Article 45. The major recommendations are:

- It specified care, protection and development opportunities for children below 3 years and integrated care and development and preschool learning opportunities for 3–6 years old.

2.8 NATIONAL CURRICULUM FRAMEWORK (2005)

This is one of the important National Curriculum Frameworks prepared and developed by the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) in India. Other National Curriculum Frameworks were published in 1975, 1988 and 2000. The framework (2005) has made suggestions about the changing syllabus, textbooks and teaching practices in schools and programmes in India. It has made the suggestion of Early Childhood Education (1986–1992) and different group discussions that took over. The main aim of NCF is to bring about reforms in the

education system by introducing a curriculum that is learner centric, has a flexible process and making teacher's role as a facilitator who supports and encourages the students.

2.8.1 Objectives of NCF

- Connecting knowledge to life outside the school.
- Shifting learning from rote learning.
- Enriching the curriculum so that it goes beyond text books.
- Making examinations more flexible and integrated into life.

2.8.2 The main focus of NCF

- Nurturing an overriding identity informed by caring concerns within the democratic polity of the country.
- Ensuring that irrespective of caste, creed, religion and sex, all are provided with a standard curriculum.
- Making learning a joyful experience without stress. It recommends major changes in the system of examination.
- Ensuring quality education for all children.
- Reducing the curriculum load based on insights provided in learning without burden.
- Developing a sense of self-reliance and dignity of the individual which would develop a sense of non-violence and oneness across the society.
- Developing a Child Centred Approach which would promote universal environment.
- Promoting national identity and students which would help to evaluate problems creatively.

- Building commitment to democratic values of equality, justice, secularism and freedom.

2.9 PRE-PRIMARY SCHOOL ACCREDITATION COUNCIL OF INDIA

Pre-primary School Accreditation Council of India is a Non-Profit Organization incorporated under sub-section (2) of section 7 and sub-section (1) of section 8 of the Companies Act, 2013 (18 of 2013) and rule 18 of the Companies Rules, 2014 by Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India specifically to provide accreditation to pre-primary schools. Primary School Accreditation Council of India is the first national level organization in India which is working for the betterment of pre-schools in their quality management. Pre-Primary School Accreditation Council of India has a recognition certificate of Government of India under section 12A of Income Tax Act, 1961.

2.9.1 Aims of Pre-Primary School Accreditation Council of India

- To evolve pre-primary education, contributing with the vision of building a better and bright future of children by accrediting & educating all entities related to pre-primary education.
- To place students at the centre of the accreditation process providing consistent learning support and development to pre-primary schools with comprehensive quality standards and a well-researched framework.

2.9.2 Features of Pre-Primary School Accreditation Council of India

- Working in research, development and standardization of pre-primary schools for the betterment of early education in India and strengthening pre-primary schools.
- Promoting Pre School Education, providing Accreditation Certificate to Pre and Primary Schools, providing School Related services, E-Learning Education, Books, Teaching Tools, Teacher Training Courses with Certificate.
- Pre-primary School Accreditation Council of India are committed to maintain its leadership in educational and other related services to the entire satisfaction of the organizations. This shall be achieved by continuous improvement in processes and systems through involvement of all schools and practical observations.
- They pledge to build a peaceful and sustainable society across the globe. And aspire that it can be built with firm and caring values in each learner for rights and responsibilities.

2.10 National Creche Scheme

National Creche Scheme earlier named as Rajiv Gandhi National Creche Scheme is being implemented as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme through States/UTs with effect from 1.12.2017 to provide day care facilities to children in age group of 6 months to 6 years of working mothers.

2.10.1 Features

- Daycare Facilities including Sleeping Facilities.
- Early Stimulation for children below 3 years and pre-school Education for 3 to 6 years old children.
- Supplementary Nutrition (to be locally sourced).
- Growth Monitoring.

- Health Check-up and Immunization.

2.11 NATIONAL EDUCATIONAL POLICY 2020

The purpose of the education system is to develop good human beings capable of rational thought and action, possessing compassion and empathy, courage and resilience, scientific temper and creative imagination, with sound ethical moorings and values. It aims at producing engaged, productive, and contributing citizens for building an equitable, inclusive, and plural society as envisaged by our Constitution.

2.11.1 Features of NEP

The fundamental principles that will guide both the education system at large, as well as the individual institutions within it are:

- Replacing the traditional 10+2 schooling system with a 5+3+3+4 system.
- Recognizing, identifying, and fostering each student's unique capabilities by sensitizing teachers as well as parents to promote each student's holistic development in both academic and non-academic spheres.
- According the highest priority to achieving Foundational Literacy and Numeracy by all students by Grade 3.
- Flexibility, so that learners have the ability to choose their learning trajectories and programmes, and thereby choose their own paths in life according to their talents and interests.
- No hard separations between arts and sciences, between curricular and extra-curricular activities, between vocational and academic streams, etc. in order to eliminate harmful hierarchies among, and silos between different areas of learning.

- Multidisciplinary and a holistic education across the sciences, social sciences, arts, humanities, and sports for a multidisciplinary world in order to ensure the unity and integrity of all knowledge.
- Emphasis on conceptual understanding rather than rote learning and learning-for-exams.
- Creativity and critical thinking to encourage logical decision-making and innovation.
- Ethics and human & Constitutional values like empathy, respect for others, cleanliness, courtesy, democratic spirit, spirit of service, respect for public property, scientific temper, liberty, responsibility, pluralism, equality, and justice.
- Promoting multilingualism and the power of language in teaching and learning.
- Life skills such as communication, cooperation, teamwork, and resilience.
- Focus on regular formative assessment for learning rather than the summative assessment that encourages today's 'coaching culture'.
- Extensive use of technology in teaching and learning, removing language barriers, increasing access for Divyang students, and educational planning and management.
- Respect for diversity and respect for the local context in all curriculum, pedagogy, and policy, always keeping in mind that education is a concurrent subject.
- Full equity and inclusion as the cornerstone of all educational decisions to ensure that all students are able to thrive in the education system.
- Synergy in curriculum across all levels of education from early childhood care and education to school education to higher education.

- Teachers and faculty as the heart of the learning process – their recruitment, continuous professional development, positive working environments and service conditions.

2.11.1 National Policy on Education and Pre-school

In 2021 there are almost 450 preschool franchise providers in India. However a positive step forward in the direction of formalising preschool education has come forth through the NEP (National Education Policy) 2020. The NEP 2020 has placed a great deal of importance on Early Childhood Care and Education, advocating that the foundational stage (3 to 8 years) is critical and requires official/formal intervention. In fact, NEP 2020 has advocated replacing the traditional 10+2 schooling system with a 5+3+3+4 system. In this structure, first five years include 3 years of pre schooling.

2.12 SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

1. What are the key points of Sargent report?
2. Compare the recommendations for preschool education between Secondary Education Commission and Indian Education Commission?
3. What is the Indian Education Commission?
4. What are the important features NEP 2020?

2.13 PRACTICAL WORK / PROJECT / ASSIGNMENT

- Critically analyse the recommendations on pre schooling by different commissions in India

For further reading:

- Bhattas, Biswas, & Sidhaj, N. (2002). Early Childhood Care and Education. Book I, New Delhi: DABHUE.
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Unit 3: DIFFERENT SETTINGS OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

3.1 INTRODUCTION

In case of preschool education, informal education is important. Even in early Childhood Education (ECCE) Centres and in preschools, nature of education is to be more informal than formal. A child's learning begins in the family. There are also interactions outside the home with peers and other members of the community. These experiences lead to the informal education of the child.

Pre-school education is today imparted through institutions like kindergartens, Montessori schools, etc. with certain aims. They also have a curriculum to achieve those aims. However, the curriculum is flexible and instructions are supposed to be informal in nature. These centres have trained teachers and also infrastructural facilities required for attaining the aims. However, many argue that education in preschool should be provided through play way methods rather than in a formal way in formal settings. Anganwadis, Balwadis, and creches also impart institutionalized services that include education but not that in a strictly formal sense. Informal education is thus the most common type of education at the preschool stage imparted by the family, community and even ECCE centres / preschools.

3.2 INSTITUTIONS OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

3.2.1 Anganwadi

Anganwadi is a type of rural child care centre in India. They were started by the Indian government in 1975 as part of the Integrated Child Development Services program to combat child hunger and malnutrition. Anganwadi means "courtyard shelter" in Hindi. A typical Anganwadi centre provides basic health care in a village. It is a part of the Indian public health care system. Basic health care activities include preventive measures and supply, nutrition education and supplementation, as well as preschool activities.

The Ministry of Women Development and Child Welfare has laid down guidelines for the responsibilities of Anganwadi workers. These guidelines include providing community support and active participation in executing this program. Some of the major activities undertaken in Anganwadis are organizing pre-school activities, providing health and nutrition education to expectant and nursing mothers, motivating families to adopt family planning, educating parents about child growth development, assisting in the implementation and execution of Kishori Shakti Yojana, educating teenage girls and parents by organizing social awareness programs and awareness activities.

Nutritional Health Education – Nutrition and health education is provided to women who are in the age group of 15 to 45 years with special attention to underprivileged and malnourished communities need to possess adequate knowledge about diet and nutrition and maintenance of good health conditions. This approach mainly focuses on educating women in the implementation of child rearing in a better way.

Immunisation – Immunisation is required for all children less than six years of age in the project against diphtheria, tetanus, cough, typhoid and tuberculosis. Immunisation against tetanus is required for all the expectant mothers. It is to be made sure that all the infants staying within the anganwadi centres should be administered vaccination against BCG, DPT, Polio and Measles before they reach one year of age.

Health Check-Up – Health check-up on a regular basis is important for young children as well as for expectant and nursing mothers. This includes antenatal care of expectant mothers, post-natal care of the nursing mothers, care of infants and of all the children who are below six years of age.

Referral Services – The problem of malnutrition is prevalent amongst young children; therefore, referral services are required in the case of the problem of malnutrition. Children who are suffering from third or fourth degree of malnutrition are taken to the hospitals, progressed PHCs, community health services or district hospitals.

Non-Formal Pre-school Education – The provision of non-formal education is made to the children in the age group of three to five years through anganwadis. The major emphasis is laid upon play, resourceful and creative activities that have the main objective of leading to psychological, intellectual and physical growth and development of the children.

Roles and Responsibilities of Anganwadi Workers (AWW) under the ICDS

The roles and responsibilities of the Anganwadi Workers are as follows:

1. To produce community support and participation in operating the program.
2. To analyse the weight of each child every month, record the weight graphically on the growth card, use referral card for referring cases of mothers and children to the sub-centres, PHC and so forth, and preserve child cards for children below six years of age and produce these cards before visiting medical and para-medical personnel.
3. To conduct the survey of the mothers and children belonging to all the families, especially within the respective working area, once a year.
4. To organize non-formal pre-school education for the children within the age group of three to five years, in order to get them acquainted with the play and creative activities that are required for their growth and development.

5. To organize supplementary nutrition feeding for the children within the age group of 6 years and to expectant and nursing mothers on locally available food and also to educate them on food preparation methods.

6. To provide health and nutrition education to expectant and nursing mothers. Married women are also counselled on areas such as family planning and birth control measures.

7. To share all the information relating to births with the Panchayat secretary, or Gram Sahayak, whoever has been notified as the Registrar or the Sub-Registrar in the village.

8. To make home visits to educate the parents in order to enable them to contribute towards effective growth and development of their children, with main emphasis put upon infants.

9. To maintain records, files and registers in an appropriate manner.

10. To assist the PHC staff in the implementation of health components of the programme.

11. To support ANM in the immunisation, health check-up, ante-natal and post-natal check-ups etc.

12. To register as it would add to the administrative work for maintenance of the stock of the two medicines i.e. Iron and Vitamin A and maintaining registers under the scheme.

13. To share the information collected under the ICDS with the ANM.

14. To maintain liaison with the other institutions and involve women school workers and girls of the primary and middle schools in the village which give recognition to the significance of their tasks.
15. To guide Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHA) involved under the National Rural Health Mission in the delivery of health care services and maintenance of the records under the ICDS scheme.

3.2.2 Balwadi

Balwadi is a native marathi name for preschools in Maharashtra. It has been defined by Grewal who is quoted by R. P. Shukla as "A rural pre-primary school run economically but scientifically using as many educational aids as possible, prepared from locally available material". It was developed by Tarabai Modak. The first balwadi was started in Bordi, a coastal village in Thane district of Maharashtra by Nutan Bal Shikshan Sangh in 1945.

Modak started two types of balwadis namely central balwadi and anganbalwadi or anganwadi. Central balwadis function during regular school hours and are centrally located whereas anganbalwadis are located in the neighbourhood of the children targeted and have hours at their convenience.

The purpose of balwadi is to provide a child facility for physical and mental growth at school age. Today, thousands of balwadis have been set up all over India by government and non-government agencies.

Balwadis were further developed as a part of the government of India's poverty alleviation programme by universalising education. They were developed for children of India's rural poor. The Balwadi nutrition programme provides food for children at these schools.

3.2.3 Creches

Creches are place where small children are looked after while their parents are working, shopping, etc. Creches are usually meant for babies and toddlers up to the age of three. Creches are designed to provide group care to children usually of ages who need care, guidance and supervision away from their home during the day.

(i) To provide day-care facilities for children (6 months to 6 years) of working mothers in the community.
(ii) Early stimulation for children below 3 years and Pre-school Education for 3 to 6 years old children.
(iii) To improve nutrition and health status of children.
(iv) To promote physical, cognitive, social and emotional development (Holistic Development) of children.
(v) To educate and empower parents / caregivers for better childcare.

3.3 TYPES OF PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

3.3.1 Montessori

The Montessori method may be a developmental approach to learning, allowing the kid to figure out a skill at her own pace to mastery. Teachers are allowed as “guides” and specialists is referred to as “work”. Learning is hands-on and social and practical life skills. Much of learning occurs through special Montessori toys/tools called manipulatives, like puzzles and blocks. Classrooms are multi-age, with attention on building a community of learners that support one another.

3.3.2 Reggio Emilia

The Reggio Emilia approach is all project-based. Students choose topics to explore. The teacher is more of a facilitator, allowing student questionnaires to guide learning. The approach emphasizes the importance of working together as a community. Students learn to observe and make inquiries about the world around them, and develop a drive for exploration and discovery. A Reggio Emilia classroom focuses on using the "four senses" to find out, and therefore the teacher becomes a facilitator, allowing student questionnaires to guide learning. The thought is that cooperative learning creates respectful and responsible citizens in the world.

3.3.3 Waldorf

The Waldorf approach focuses on a child's spirit, soul, and body. Hands-on play-based learning that happens in a home-like setting with predictable routines. Teachers seek to foster a drive for learning, and to uncover a child's innate strengths and skills. The Waldorf method is sort of different than most for a couple of other reasons. It excludes any kind of media (computers, video, or any electronics), and doesn't involve traditional academics.

3.3.4 Kindergarten

A German educator Friedrich Froebel is credited with coining the term kindergarten as he set up schools for 3–7 years old, which was significantly smaller than the contemporary norm. Froebel used a series of toys known as "Gifts" which help children learn skills like 3D visualization, imagination etc.

3.3.5 High Scope

In a High Scope program, a student's day consists of hands-on experiences in well-organized classrooms with consistent daily routines. There is a focus on academics, based on child development research. Teachers use a way of scaffolding, supporting

students at their current level and nudging them to increase and build skills. A High Scope program uses an approach called active participatory learning. A core of this method is “Plan-Do-Review” sequence. Before beginning an activity, students actively plan and express idea for what they are setting out to do, who they’ll do it with, how it will go. Once an activity is completed, they review how it went, taking ownership in the learning process.

3.3.6 Bank Street

The Bank Street approach is a play-based, active learning through experience. This program was also developed based on child development research, with attention on mental, social, emotional, and physical growth. Classroom materials are basic and open-ended to encourage imagination, and before the teacher is seen as a facilitator. Lessons happen through hands-on activities like puzzles, blocks, art, and play.

3.3.7 Parent Co-Ops

If you would like to be directly involved with your child’s school experience, consider a Parent Co-op preschool, where parents work closely with the classroom. In these programs, the parents involved usually choose a teacher to hire. The Moms and Dads might help with lessons, observe classroom behaviour, and share within the business operation by serving on the school’s board of directors.

A co-op can focus on any preschool philosophy that parents desire, or even combine multiple philosophies for a unique approach to learning. It’s important to notice, however, that co-ops require many responsibilities and time commitments.

3.4 SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

1. How can you differentiate Anganwadi and Balwadi?
2. What are the features of Creches?

3. What are the types of pre-school education?

3.5 PRACTICAL WORK / PROJECT / ASSIGNMENT

Visit a Pre-school educational institution having more than 10 years of history and study its development and report it.

For further reading:

• Bhatia, S. Biswas, & Siddiqi, N. (2002). *Early Childhood Care and Education*. Book I. New Delhi: DABA House.

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Unit 4: EDUCATIONAL PHILOSOPHY OF DIFFERENT THINKERS

4.1 INTRODUCTION

Philosophy in a general sense is conceived a person's "sum of his fundamental beliefs and convictions". Philosophy is a guide for living. Philosophy is the study or creation of theories about basic things such as the nature of existence, knowledge, thought, or about how people should live. The word philosophy comes from a combination of two Greek words- "philos" meaning "love" and "sophia" meaning "wisdom". Etymologically, philosophy means the love of wisdom.

4.2 BRANCHES OF PHILOSOPHY

While studying the philosophical thoughts of a philosopher, we study his thinking in different branches of philosophy. These branches of philosophy are as follows:

• **Epistemology.** Philosophy is the search for knowledge. This search is critical. Hence, the first problem which arises before a philosopher is about the nature of knowledge and its limitations. Therefore, epistemology is the most fundamental branch of philosophy. It discusses philosophically truth, falsehood, validity of knowledge, limits of knowledge and nature of knowledge, knower and known etc.

• **Metaphysics.** This is the study of existence, reality or essence. Its main branches are as follows:

○ **(i) Cosmogony:** This is a study of creation. Is the world created, or is it eternal? How was world created? Why was it created? Who created the world? What is the purpose of creation? All these are the problems of cosmogony.

○ **(ii) Ontology:** The main problems of ontology are: Is the world one or is it both one and many? What is the ultimate reality? Is the reality one or is it many or is it both one and many? If reality is many, what is the ontological relation between these many elements? All these are ontological questions.

○ **(iii) Philosophy of self:** This is mainly concerned with the philosophical analysis of self. What is self? What is its relation with the body? Is it free or does it depend on the body? Is it one or many? All these are the problems of philosophy of self.

○ **(iv) Eschatology:** The discussion of the soul after death, the nature of the other world etc. form the subject matter of eschatology.

• **Axiology.** This branch of philosophy deals with values. It has been divided into the following three philosophical studies:

○ **(i) Ethics:** Ethics discusses the criteria of right or good.

○ **(ii) Aesthetics:** Aesthetics discusses the nature and criteria of beauty.

○ **(iii) Logic:** It studies truth. The subject matter of logic includes the method of judgment, types of propositions, hypothesis, definition, comparison, division, classification and fundamental laws of thoughts, etc.

4.3 EDUCATIONAL PHILOSOPHY

Philosophy and education are closely inter-related and inter-dependent. Philosophy points out the ways and education follows it. Without philosophy, education would be a blind effort and without education, philosophy would be crippled. Philosophy

and education are two sides of same coin; the former is the contemplative side while the latter is the active side. Education is the process and philosophy is the product and also examines the nature and problems of education. Education is a conscious dynamic process with purpose of guidance and supervision. Without proper guidance and supervision, it cannot achieve its goal. Philosophy determines the goal of life and so provides suitable aim of education. Education attempts to reach that goal. Without the help of philosophy, education cannot be a successful process of development and achievement. True education is practical only by a true philosophy.

4.4 EDUCATIONAL PHILOSOPHERS

Great Philosophers have been Great Educationists also. History bears eloquent testimony to the fact that great philosophers have been great educationists also. Plato, Rousseau, Froebel, John Dewey, Mahatma Gandhi, Rabindranath Tagore and others who were great philosophers of their times have also talked about educational problems. Their philosophical treatises have been important guides for educational planning. All great philosophers have employed education as a means to translate their philosophical ideas into practice for the people to follow and develop themselves.

4.4.1 Plato (427–347 BCE)

Plato was born in Athens in 427 B.C. Plato began his philosophical career as a student of Socrates. About 387 BC, Plato founded a school in Athens, in a grove sacred to the demigod Academus, called the Academy. He was an idealist philosopher.

4.4.1.2 Plato's Works

Republic is a dialogue which discusses the education necessary to produce such a society. It is an education of a selected people, carefully chosen and trained by the

state, to translate into modern idiom, Plato refers to the process by which the physical and spiritual development of the individual is of paramount importance. It is the education of the total individual. Plato discusses early education mainly in the Republic. He discusses early education mainly in the Republic, on which he was still at work at the end of his life.

4.4.1.3 Plato's Educational thoughts

The highest goal of education, Plato believed, is the knowledge of Good; to nurture a man to a better human being. It is not merely an awareness of particular benefits and pleasures.

There are 3 sources of knowledge:

• Knowledge obtained from senses i.e., knowledge of objects, colours, taste, touch etc. But Plato does not consider this as real knowledge.

• An opinion regarding any object, but this knowledge cannot be relied upon.

• Knowledge obtained through reason. It is the highest degree of knowledge which includes virtues like truth, goodness and beauty. This knowledge is idealistic and is based on original thinking. The characteristic of knowledge is that it is found in the form of universal truth.

AGE	SCHOOL	SPECIAL DEVELOPMENT OR STUDIES
Birth to 3 years	Infancy	Bodily growth, sensory life, no fear, child reacts to pleasure and pain.
4 to 6 years	Nursery	Play, fairy tales, nursery rhymes, myths, get rid of self-will.

6 to 13 years	Elementary school	Play, poetry, reading, writing, singing, geometry, religion, manners, numbers.
13 to 16 years	Instrumental Music	Play the cithara, religious hymns, memorize poetry, arithmetic (theory).
16 to 20 years	Gymnastics and the military training	Formal gymnastics and military training. No intellectual training.
20 to 30 years	Sciences	Coordination of reason and habits. Physical sciences.
30 to 35 years	Dialectic	Philosophy, psychology, sociology, government, law, education.
35 to 50 years	Service to State	Serve as philosopher.
50 to end	Philosophers	Higher Philosophy.

4.4.2 Jean Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778 A.D.)

Jean Jacques Rousseau was born in Geneva (June 28). He became famous as a French political philosopher and educationist. His philosophy of education has been called naturalism. His overall work had a significant impact on political theory and practice in general, and on education after Plato's Republic. In his work he criticized formal and artificial education.

According to Rousseau, God makes all things good, man meddles with them and they become evil. According to him education means, "Natural development of organs and powers of the child." Without understanding the natural needs of the child useful

education for the child cannot be provided. Rousseau has outlined his scheme of education in his book *Emile*.

4.4.2.1 Pre-school Education

Rousseau expressed his views on education including preschool education in his book *Emile*. The text is divided into five books, the first three are dedicated to the child Emile. The fourth to an exploration of adolescent and the fifth to outlining the education of his female counterpart, as well as to Emile's domestic and civic life.

4.4.2.2 Education at Infancy according to Rousseau

The child is active in nature, and never seen inactive. He should not force to do any work. It is not good to form any habits in children. Child begins to play with whatever he gets and throws it and sometimes puts it in mouth. So this should be natural in infancy branches, leaves and fruits could be his toys. In the beginning it is necessary to give leaves and fruits suitable for natural ideas. Teaching of speaking or stress on speaking before the proper time is not useful. Child should be given full freedom and proper environment for his natural activities.

4.4.2.3 Education during Childhood according to Rousseau

According to Rousseau, the period of childhood extends from 5 to 12 years. During this period, emphasis should be laid on physical education and training of senses. The child should not be burdened with bookish knowledge. Education should be provided through activities which develop the body and senses. The child should be given freedom to move, play and explore the natural environment. Learning should come through direct experiences rather than verbal instruction.

Rousseau believed that punishment and rewards should be avoided during this stage. The teacher should create such situations where the child learns naturally from the

consequences of his actions. Moral education should not be taught directly but should develop gradually through experiences.

4.4.2.4 Education during Adolescence according to Rousseau

Rousseau considered adolescence as the period from 12 to 15 years. During this stage, intellectual development begins. The child becomes capable of reasoning and understanding cause and effect relationships. Education at this stage should include the study of science, mathematics, geography and history.

Rousseau emphasized learning by doing. Practical activities and experiments should be encouraged. The teacher should guide the learner rather than impose knowledge. Emotional development also takes place during this period and the child begins to develop social feelings.

4.4.2.5 Education during Youth according to Rousseau

According to Rousseau, the period from 15 to 20 years is the stage of youth. During this stage, moral and social education becomes important. The individual develops emotions, feelings and sentiments. Education should aim at developing character, self-control and moral values.

At this stage, the learner should be prepared for social life. Education should help the individual to understand duties and responsibilities towards society. Religious education may also be introduced to develop a sense of morality and spirituality.

4.4.3 John Heinrich Pestalozzi (1746–1827 A.D.)

John Heinrich Pestalozzi was born at Zurich in Switzerland. He was a great educationist and social reformer. He was deeply influenced by Rousseau's philosophy of naturalism. Pestalozzi believed that education should be based on the nature of the child and aim at the harmonious development of all the faculties.

According to Pestalozzi, education is the natural, harmonious and progressive development of man's innate powers. He emphasized the development of head, heart and hand.

4.4.3.1 Pestalozzi's Educational Philosophy

Pestalozzi emphasized learning through sense perception. According to him, sense impressions are the foundation of all knowledge. Education should proceed from simple to complex, from known to unknown and from concrete to abstract.

Education should be child-centred. The teacher should act as a guide. Love and sympathy should be the basis of education.

4.4.3.2 Pestalozzi and Pre-school Education

Pestalozzi gave great importance to early childhood education. He believed that the mother is the first teacher and the home is the first school. Early education should focus on developing good habits, moral values and sensory experiences.

Play, singing, drawing, storytelling and physical exercises should be included in preschool education. Rote learning should be avoided.

4.4.4 Friedrich August Froebel (1782–1852 A.D.)

Friedrich August Froebel was born in Thuringia, Germany. He is known as the father of kindergarten. Froebel believed that education should help the child to develop

naturally and freely. He emphasized the importance of play in early childhood education.

4.4.4.1 Froebel's Educational Philosophy

Froebel believed that education is a process of unfolding the divine potential within the child. Play is the highest expression of human development in childhood. He emphasized self-activity, unity and harmony.

He introduced educational materials known as "Gifts and Occupations".

4.4.4.2 Froebel and Pre-school Education

Froebel considered early childhood as the most important stage of development. Kindergarten activities include songs, games, stories and creative activities. Education should promote social skills, cooperation and discipline.

4.4.5 Maria Montessori (1870–1952 A.D.)

Maria Montessori was an Italian physician and educationist. She was the first woman doctor in Italy. She developed a scientific method of education based on her observation and experiments with children. Montessori believed that education should help the child's natural development.

4.4.5.1 Montessori's Educational Philosophy

Montessori believed that education is a natural process carried out by the child and is not acquired by listening to words but by experiences in the environment. She

emphasized self-education and freedom. According to her, the child is an active learner and education should provide opportunities for independent learning.

4.4.5.2 Prepared Environment

According to Montessori, the environment plays an important role in the development of the child. The classroom environment should be attractive, well-organized and child-centred. Furniture and materials should be suitable to the size and needs of children. Children should have freedom to move and choose activities according to their interests.

4.4.5.3 Montessori Classroom

Montessori classrooms are designed to encourage independence. Materials are arranged systematically on low shelves so that children can access them easily. Children are allowed to work individually or in small groups. The teacher acts as a guide and observer rather than a traditional instructor.

4.4.5.4 Role of Teacher

The teacher in a Montessori classroom is known as a directress. Her role is to prepare the environment and guide the child. She observes the child's activities and provides help only when necessary. The teacher should respect the child's individuality and allow self-directed learning.

4.4.5.5 Educational Method

Montessori's method emphasizes learning through activity. Education is based on sensory experiences. Children learn by manipulating materials and engaging in purposeful activities. Repetition of activities helps in mastery and concentration.

4.4.5.6 Montessori Materials

Montessori materials are scientifically designed to develop the senses and intellect. Each material has a specific purpose and allows self-correction. Materials help children to develop concepts of size, shape, colour, number and language.

4.4.5.7 Principles of Montessori Method

- Education should be child-centred
- Freedom within discipline
- Learning through senses
- Self-education
- Individual work
- Respect for the child

4.4.5.8 Sensitive Periods

Montessori identified certain sensitive periods in a child's development during which the child is especially receptive to learning certain skills. These periods are temporary and must be utilized effectively.

4.4.5.9 Process of Learning

Montessori explained learning as a three-stage process:

- Presentation of the material
- Practice and repetition
- Mastery of the activity

4.4.5.10 Merits

- Child-centred education

- Development of independence
- Learning by doing
- Individual attention
- Development of concentration

4.4.5.11 Demerits

- Less emphasis on imagination
- Expensive materials
- Limited group activities
- Requires trained teachers

4.4.6 John Dewey (1859–1952 A.D.)

John Dewey was born in Vermont, U.S.A. He was a philosopher, psychologist and educationist. He is regarded as the chief exponent of pragmatism. Dewey believed that education is a social process and learning takes place through experience. According to him, education is not a preparation for future life but life itself.

Dewey emphasized learning by doing. He believed that knowledge is gained through interaction with the environment. Education should be based on the interests and experiences of the child. School should be a miniature society where children learn to live democratically.

4.4.6.1 Dewey's Educational Philosophy

Dewey believed that education should develop problem-solving abilities. Education should be activity-oriented and related to real-life situations. He opposed rote learning and rigid curriculum.

According to Dewey, the aim of education is social efficiency and democratic citizenship. The curriculum should be flexible and adaptable to the needs of the child. The teacher's role is to guide, stimulate and facilitate learning rather than to impose knowledge.

4.4.6.2 Dewey and Pre-school Education

Dewey stressed that early childhood education should be experiential. Activities such as play, projects, experiments and group activities should form the basis of preschool education.

He believed that preschool education should encourage curiosity, creativity and cooperation. The classroom environment should provide opportunities for children to explore and interact with their surroundings.

4.4.7 Mahatma Gandhi (1869–1948 A.D.)

Mahatma Gandhi was born at Porbandar in Gujarat. He was a great leader, philosopher and educationist. Gandhi's philosophy of education is known as Basic Education or Nai Talim. He believed that education should aim at the all-round development of the individual.

Gandhi emphasized the dignity of labour. Education should be productive and self-supporting. Manual work should form an integral part of education. Education should develop moral values, self-reliance and social responsibility.

4.4.7.1 Gandhiji's Views on Education

"By education I mean an all-round drawing out of the best in child and man – body, mind and spirit."

— M. K. Gandhi (1937)

According to Gandhiji:

- Education should develop body, mind and soul.
- Education should be related to life and social needs.
- Education should be concrete and activity-based.
- Education should be imparted in the mother tongue.
- Education should promote truth, non-violence and self-discipline.

4.4.7.2 Gandhiji and Pre-school Education

Gandhiji believed that preschool education should focus on the formation of good habits, moral development and social behaviour. Activities such as storytelling, songs, games and simple craft work should be included.

The environment should be simple, natural and child-friendly. Learning should take place through activity and experience.

4.5 SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

1. Explain Plato's educational philosophy.
2. Discuss Rousseau's views on education.
3. Write a note on Froebel's contribution to pre-school education.
4. Explain Gandhiji's philosophy of education.

4.6 PRACTICAL WORK / PROJECT / ASSIGNMENT

Visit a nearby pre-school and observe the teaching-learning process. Prepare a report highlighting the educational philosophy followed in the school.

4.7 FURTHER READING

- Bhatia, S., Biswas, S. & Siddiqi, N. (2002). *Early Childhood Care and Education*. Book I. New Delhi: DABA House.
- Aggarwal, J. C. (2002). *Theory and Principles of Education*. New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House.
- NCERT. (2005). *National Curriculum Framework*. New Delhi.

Unit 5: PEDAGOGICAL APPROACHES

5.1 INTRODUCTION

Pedagogy and pedagogue come from the Greek paidos "boy, child" plus agogos "leader." An early year education programme is transacted in a child-centric manner, adopting a holistic approach that views the child's learning not limited to what the teacher transacts in the classroom setting, but as being co-created by the children, in the context of their natural and social environment, including home and community. The penetration of technology like computers, video, television, telephones, radio, and telecommunications networks have exerted great influence on how we live, work, play and learn. In order to cope up with the challenges of life, children and adults need greater ability to learn how to learn, possess problem solving, critical thinking skills, and to be resilient in the face of fast-moving change.

The time to begin preparing children for the challenges and demands of the future is when they are young, curious and excited learners. Children learn through

experiences and relationships with parents, teachers and friends. Hence, the learning experiences should tap the natural curiosity and excitement of children. This includes not only supporting the emerging skills in reading, writing and mathematics, but also in the skills of critical thinking, collaboration, communication, creativity, technology literacy, and social-emotional development known as 21st Century skills. These skills have significant impact on the learning and development of young children.

It is expected that the strengthening of key cognitive skills included in goal 3 would also contribute to providing the child a sound foundation for meeting the challenges of negotiating new technologies in the years ahead which should be enforced while transacting the curriculum.

5.2 DIFFERENT APPROACHES

There are different approaches for curriculum transaction such as theme based, activity based, project/inquiry based and emergent curriculum.

5.2.1 Theme Based Approach

Theme-based approach is commonly used by the educators across the world. It attempts to tie in various skills and knowledge to be acquired by children into a whole, organized around a specific theme, such as myself, plants, animals, fruits, vegetables, etc. A deliberate focus on a given topic enables very young children to become skilled at learning skills and processes required to gather and process information in later life.

When we take a particular theme and help children to actively and visibly build knowledge on that theme, we enable children acquire skills to make learning more efficient in the future. To plan the curriculum, a thematic approach each theme could

be spread over a 2 months. This thematic coverage might be organized in a way that makes sense to the children. For example, if the chosen theme was plants, it could be spread over a duration of 1 month with various sub-themes such as parts of plants, types of plants, uses of plants, taking care of plants, etc., each covered in detail over a one-week period.

Theme teaching is generally carried out according to a detailed predesigned lesson plan. Such an approach is largely teacher-directed with very limited scope to allow for child-initiated learning.

5.2.2 Play Based Approach

Children learn best through play. Children should engage in play activities which are neither too challenging nor too easy for their developmental level. In a play-based approach stimulating materials and activities are made available by the teacher and children select activities according to their interest at each point of time and learn at their own pace. In this approach the teacher takes the role of a facilitator and does not carry out any specific structured activities. In order to enable children to benefit from this approach teachers need to observe and identify learning opportunities and make play materials available accordingly. If a teacher is not sensitive and responsive, it may lead to loss of learning opportunities and learning by doing. Any play activities should be purposeful and lead onto the next. A project may not constitute the whole day's schedule. Teachers can allocate half a day for the project and plan activities for the remaining half.

Play based approach stimulates curiosity and exploration and leads to mastery of body controls, encourages creativity and social skills, and develops emotional balance and language skills.

5.2.3 Activity based Approach

The primary belief of activity-based approach is that children learn through participation in activities. It provides opportunities for exploration and experimentation with different teaching-learning materials. The sensory experience and action make learning better and more impactful. This leads to an exciting journey of discovery and enhanced understanding. A preschool teacher embeds the learning goals in various types of activities such as outdoor and indoor play, storytelling, art and music activities, organized in a preschool class.

5.2.4 Projects / Inquiry based Approach

A project is inquiry-based investigation or in-depth study of a topic or theme, usually done by small groups within a class, an entire class or sometimes by individual children. The teachers offer some open-ended triggers and then observe the children, listen to their stories, their questions, see how they navigate the activity, take note of their interest levels and talk with the children. Children decide what they want to know more about and investigate further.

Then with the variety of materials on offer to the children, the teachers encourage children's engagement in activities, to go deeper and deeper to find answers to their questions. The project makes children's learning visible through modelling or building, collage or drawing, dramatic play or music, any means at all. These activities are not pre-planned or designed. They are subtly suggested to the children and the discoveries from one experience lead onto the next. A project may not constitute the whole day's schedule. Teachers can allocate half a day for the project and plan activities for the remaining half.

5.2.5 Emergent Curriculum

Emergent curriculum is defined as a process where teachers plan activities and projects based on the specific group of children they are working with, taking into

account their skills, needs and interests. Teachers consider observations and documentation of children. Teachers practicing emergent curriculum also observe children, taking time to reflect and act on their observations of children. This philosophy emphasizes observation, relationship building, flexible and adaptable methods, inquiry and play-based learning. Curriculum is child-initiated, collaborative and responsive to the children's needs.

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5.3 CURRICULUM OF PRE-SCHOOL

Curriculum is a standard-based sequence of planned experiences where students practice and achieve proficiency in content and applied learning skills. Curriculum is the central guide for all educators as to understand what is essential for teaching and learning, so that every student has access to rigorous academic experiences.

This curriculum has been developed with an assumption based on empirical and theoretical understanding that children are generally ready for preschool by the age of 3 years. This curriculum has been designed in a progressive manner for 3 years of preschool education before Class I, between the age of 3–6 years.

While there is a broad universal sequence of development, yet there are differences among children in terms of their prior experiences that children bring to preschool,

their context and abilities. Typically, there is also a difference of development among children of the same age. Therefore, the curriculum should be transacted with adequate flexibility to accommodate this diversity and should not be seen as rigidly tied down to a particular chronological age of children. The curriculum needs to be customized by the teacher at any given point of time to meet diverse learning needs of any age group.

Given the children's age and the fact that they are likely to be away from home for the first time, considerable time may be allotted for free play to develop a sense of liking for the new environment and people. This will form the basis for gradually moving them on to more structured activities.

Goals

The present curriculum covers the three broads:

- Goals
- Key skills and concepts to be developed
- Pedagogical processes

5.3.1 Goals of Preschool Education Curriculum

Learning and development in children is holistic, it advances in the areas of health, cognition, personal and social development and well-being simultaneously. Children learn at different times, in different ways and at different rates. The aim of preschool education is to enhance child's full potential and lay the foundation for all-round development and lifelong learning. The curriculum addresses all the domains of development through the following three broad goals:

Goal 1: Children Maintain Good Health and Well-being

The early childhood years are of critical importance for laying the foundation for optimal physical, socio-emotional and psychological health and well-being of children for life. These are the years when opportunities and encouragement are given to strengthen their large and fine muscles, eye-hand coordination, physical stamina and endurance.

Alongside, their sense of identity and social skills are developing, as they initiate and engage in more and more play-based activities with other children. The engagement is initially in pairs and then gradually in smaller and then larger groups as they learn to play, work and live with others in harmonious ways. They also begin to appreciate how each one of them is different and how these differences need to be not only accepted but also respected.

Goal 2: Children become Effective Communicators

By the time three-years-old come into a preschool in monolingual cultures, they have typically already begun to communicate their needs, likes and dislikes orally in their home language, which is also the school language. In more literate families, children from infancy (0–2 years) are exposed to books and reading through storytelling by elders or by seeing others read. The preschool curriculum is therefore required to build on all these early experiences and exposure and further children's communication skills, so that they can express and describe their experiences more effectively. It also ensures that children are able to receive and share information and develop higher order skills, critical and creative thinking.

Goal 3: Children become Involved Learners and Connect with their Immediate Environment

The young child is curious and enchanted with the world, its colours, shapes, sounds, sizes and forms. But most of all she/he is enchanted with the people around. This ability to connect with others and to share feelings with them forms a special basis for learning, the cultural and social basis of human learning.

The children in the preschool years begin to understand the world around them by making sense of it as they see it. If a set of five pencils is laid out in a way that it is spread apart and covers more space and another set of five pencils is laid out in a way that it is placed close together but covers less space, the preschoolers will tend to see the latter as having fewer pencils although the number is the same. They are governed by the space covered as they see it and not by the concept of number which is still developing.

A major goal of preschool education is, therefore, to help children move towards more logical thinking by helping them graduate from their perception-bound to more concept-based understanding. This gets addressed by helping children form concepts related to the world around them through direct experience and interactions with the physical, social and natural environment. A sound framework for planning their learning experiences is therefore essential.

5.3.2 Key Concepts and Skills to be Acquired from Preschool Education

The curriculum identifies the key concepts and skills to be developed in children during preschool years. These concepts and skills are organised under different developmental domains. The learning experiences provided in preschool should help children acquire these concepts and skills in an integrated manner through play and meaningful activities.

The key domains of development addressed in the preschool curriculum include physical development, personal, social and emotional development, language and

literacy development, cognitive development and creative and aesthetic development.

Physical Development

Physical development includes the development of gross motor skills, fine motor skills and eye-hand coordination. Opportunities should be provided for children to participate in activities that strengthen their muscles, improve balance, coordination and control of body movements. Activities such as running, jumping, climbing, throwing, catching, drawing, painting and manipulating small objects support physical development.

Children also learn to take care of their personal hygiene and health. Habits related to cleanliness, nutrition, rest and safety are gradually developed during this stage.

Personal, Social and Emotional Development

Personal, social and emotional development refers to the development of self-awareness, self-confidence, independence and social relationships. Preschool experiences should help children develop a positive self-image and learn to express and manage their emotions.

Children learn to interact with peers and adults, share materials, take turns and cooperate during group activities. They also learn to understand and respect differences among individuals and develop empathy towards others.

Language and Literacy Development

Language development includes listening, speaking, reading and writing skills. Preschool curriculum should provide rich opportunities for children to listen to

stories, rhymes and songs, engage in conversations and express their ideas and feelings.

Early literacy skills such as print awareness, vocabulary development, phonological awareness and interest in books are developed through storytelling, picture reading, role play and other language-based activities. Writing skills are gradually developed through drawing, scribbling and copying simple shapes and letters.

Cognitive Development

Cognitive development refers to the development of thinking, reasoning, problem-solving and concept formation. Preschool curriculum should help children explore their environment, ask questions, make observations and draw conclusions.

Children develop basic concepts related to number, shape, size, colour, pattern, time and space through hands-on activities and play. Opportunities for experimentation, classification, sorting and matching help in cognitive development.

Creative and Aesthetic Development

Creative and aesthetic development includes the development of imagination, creativity and appreciation of beauty. Children should be encouraged to express themselves through art, music, dance, drama and other creative activities.

Such activities provide opportunities for self-expression, emotional release and enjoyment. They also help in developing fine motor skills and aesthetic sensibility.

5.3.3 Pedagogical Process

The teaching-learning process should be more interactive and learner-centered. To ensure child centered and child friendly teaching-learning process, the teacher should follow the various ways:

- Encouraging children to ask questions
- Providing hands on experiences
- Using play way method
- Using child's own experience as a base for learning
- Providing a rich environment where child can explore and learn
- Encouraging children to participate in various activities
- Providing opportunities for social interaction
- Ensuring that every child feels safe and secure in the classroom.

5.4 EVALUATION IN PRE-SCHOOL EDUCATION

Assessment is a process of gathering and analyzing information about children's learning and development. It helps the teacher to understand the child's progress and identify the areas where the child needs more support. Assessment should be continuous and comprehensive. It should be done in a natural and non-threatening environment. The teacher should use various tools and techniques for assessment such as observation, checklist, portfolio, etc.

5.5 PROGRAMME PLANNING

Programme planning is a process of deciding in advance what is to be done, when, where, how and by whom. It helps the teacher to organize the day's activities in a systematic and meaningful way. A well-planned programme ensures that all the developmental needs of the children are met.

5.5.1 Principles of Programme Planning:

The following principles should be kept in mind while planning a programme:

- Age appropriateness
- Need based
- Interest of the children
- Flexibility
- Balance between active and quiet activities
- Balance between indoor and outdoor activities
- Balance between individual and group activities.

5.5.2 Components of Programme Planning:

The following are the components of programme planning:

- Theme based approach
- Play based approach
- Activity based approach.

5.5.3 Suggestive Day's Schedule

- Prayer
- Wishing and informal talk
- Circle time (Teacher initiated Large Group Activity)

Circle time is mainly meant for the conversation including both formal or guided and informal or free in nature. Formal conversation is initiated by the teacher around a particular topic or theme whereas, the informal conversation is free of any theme where children talk about anything they want to talk. By participating in conversations

children learn to listen to others, respond properly and express themselves. They learn to formulate ideas and answers.

The day's routine can be planned keeping in mind the principles of programme planning based on the age, needs, interest and developmental level of the children.

- Health Check Up
- Ice breaking activity (Reading a book or singing songs/ rhymes etc. should be done to give variety to the circle time and also catch the attention of the young children.)
- Break
- Subject
- Break
- Subject
- Activity sheets/books
- Activity / play (indoor or outdoor)

Goodbye circle activities:

- Recapitulation of whole day's program
- Story/rhymes
- Activities they like
- Preparation for the next day's activities
- Asking children to share their experiences with their parents.

5.6 SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

- What is pedagogy?
- What is the different between Theme Based Approach and Play Based Approach?
- What are the important skills acquired from preschool education?
- What you mean by VARK model?
- OBE stands for _____

5.7 PRACTICAL WORK/ PROJECT / ASSIGNMENT

- Prepare a Day plan for Preschool Education

DECLARATION

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Academic Note

Learners are encouraged to supplement this material with practical observations, classroom activities, and reference resources to enhance their understanding of early childhood care and education.